

Operations diagnostic methodology

A field-to-executive approach for locating service, flow and productivity constraints.

AUDIENCE	Operations workstream leads and transformation teams
PURPOSE	Turn observed operating friction into prioritized, implementable improvement choices.
VERSION	1.0 As of 13 Jul 2026
OWNER	Avery Calder Operations Practice

Method in six moves

Set the service outcome; map the end-to-end flow; observe work where it occurs; quantify delays, defects and demand; identify root causes; design experiments and an implementation roadmap.

Evidence standards

- Distinguish observed fact, stakeholder perception and modeled estimate.
- Use time windows and units consistently.
- Triangulate interview claims with process, system or sampling evidence.
- Label all demonstration datasets synthetic.

Control record: minimum evidence for a review

Control point	Evidence to retain	Decision rule
Scope	Decision statement and named audience	Proceed only when scope is bounded.
Evidence	Source/assumption log and review notes	Separate verified facts from estimates.
Action	Owner, timing and next review date	Assign one accountable owner.

Application notes

Worked example: Client Alpha

Synthetic example data. Client Alpha Phase 1 Finance approved diagnostic budget of JPY 42.8M funds the diagnostic only. Do not infer operational savings from it. Use a separate hypothesis table for cycle-time and rework opportunities.

Root-cause test

Ask whether the issue recurs, where it begins, what condition triggers it, and which owner can change the condition. Avoid treating a downstream symptom as a cause because it is easier to measure.

Decision worksheet

Control point	Evidence to retain	Decision rule
Scope	Decision statement and named audience	Proceed only when scope is bounded.
Evidence	Source/assumption log and review notes	Separate verified facts from estimates.
Action	Owner, timing and next review date	Assign one accountable owner.

Practice note. Use concise records that make the next decision easier. This guide is an internal operating reference; it is not a substitute for engagement-specific governance.

Execution and review

Experiment design

Specify baseline, intervention, owner, duration, guardrails and success measure. Pilot in a bounded area, review the result with frontline operators, then scale only when evidence supports it.

Practical checklist

- Confirm the purpose and audience before working from the guide.
- Maintain clear distinction between verified facts, assumptions and synthetic examples.
- Record accountable owner, next step and decision date.
- Invite an independent reviewer when conclusions or access risks are material.
- Update the engagement record after the decision is made.

Sign-off prompts

Control point	Evidence to retain	Decision rule
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Evidence	Source/assumption log and review notes	Separate verified facts from estimates.
Action	Owner, timing and next review date	Assign one accountable owner.

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